FOR COUNSELOR USE · ADULTS

My Inner Landscape: Facilitator Guide

An expressive arts exploration of who someone is, who they're becoming, and what's shaping both. A conversation, not an assessment.

Suggested flow (35 to 40 minutes of a 50-minute session)

1. Invite 3 min	"Would you like to try a visual way of looking at where you are right now? You can write, draw, or use single words. It's fine to skip anything."
2. Create 12 to 15 min	Let them fill the tree quietly, in any order. Offer colored pens; optional soft music they choose. Stay present without commenting.
3. Walk the tree 10 to 12 min	"Where would you like to start telling me about it?" Follow their meaning, part by part.
4. Notice connections 5 to 7 min	Look at the whole tree together (see Integration questions).
5. Close 3 min	"What's one small thing you want to tend this week?" Invite them to keep the page or photograph it.

Prompts for each part

Roots	"Who and what shaped you? What did you learn growing up about feelings, success, or being loved?" · "Which roots do you want to keep nourishing?"
Soil	"What do you need to feel steady and alive? Which needs are well fed right now, and which are running low?"
Trunk	"What do you stand for? What qualities have carried you through hard times?"
Branches	"Where does your time and energy go? Which branches feel alive, and which feel heavy or obligatory?"
Leaves	"Who and what sustains you? Where do you feel you belong?"
New growth	"If this tree grew the way you truly want, what would appear here?"
Weather	"What's pressing on you right now? How does this weather reach the rest of the tree?"
Falling leaves	"What are you ready to release, or what has already fallen away? Is there anything to grieve there?"

Continued on page 2: integration questions, getting unstuck, and variations.

Deepening the conversation

Integration questions

“Looking at the whole tree, what stands out to you?”

“Where do your branches match your trunk, and where is there a gap?” (values and daily life)

“How does the weather affect your soil and branches?”

“Which roots feed your new growth, and which might be holding it back?”

When someone gets stuck

Offer a color, a symbol, or one word instead of sentences.

“If you did know, what might it be?” A “?” on the page is a complete answer.

For people who intellectualize: “Where do you notice that in your body as you write it?”

Comment on process, not quality: “You spent a long time on the roots.”

What to listen for

Gaps between trunk (values) and branches (daily life): often where burnout, restlessness, or guilt lives.

Inherited roots that still steer choices: “shoulds” from family or culture.

Thin soil: needs that have gone unnamed or unmet for a long time.

Bare leaves: isolation, or connection that feels effortful rather than nourishing.

Variations

Two trees: one for “the tree I am now” and one for “the tree I'm growing into,” across one or two sessions.

Transitions: spend extra time on falling leaves and new growth.

Revisit later: return to the same tree weeks later and notice what has changed.

Couples: each partner draws their own tree, then they share roots and soil with each other.

Do not interpret the symbols for the client. Let them choose how deep to go; roots can touch painful history, so slow down and check in.

Inspired by the Tree of Life approach developed by Ncazelo Ncube and David Denborough (Dulwich Centre). Original worksheet and guide by Woohee (Elise) Kwak.